

individual developer branches are generally available only as source archive and not as binary builds. Hence, if you want to test the very latest version (read unreleased) compiling from source may be your only option.

Now that we have a motive to compile our code instead of using pre-built binary packages, let us move towards the first step, which is acquiring them.

3.2 Acquiring the source

It can be a daunting task for a newcomer to merely acquire the source code and extract the actual source code tree from compressed packages. This section will cover that aspect.

A point of note over here is that in over 99 per cent cases the file you will download will be in a compressed archive but not in the ZIP format popular with Windows user, but as a tarball (.GZ or .TGZ) extension. Your Linux distribution would have come by default with a tool to handle such compressed packages.

The other method is to use a version control client.

It is often said that the art of writing good software is to keep rewriting it. That is why most software development teams use some form of version control. Cooperating developers commit their changes incrementally to a common source repository, which allows them to collaborate on code without resorting to crude file-sharing techniques (shared drives, email). Source control tools track all prior versions of all files, allowing developers to “time travel” backward and forward in their software to determine when and where bugs are introduced. These tools also identify conflicting simultaneous modifications made by two (poorly-communicating) team members, forcing them to



There are generally two ways to download the source code, one is the direct download link method and the other is using a revision control client. The first one is the more familiar method, where you go to the software's web site and spot the “download” link and chose the source archive from there.

Tip

Windows Users can use another open source tool called “7-Zip” to handle all your uncompressing needs. This is available as a free download in both binary and source format at www.7-zip.org/download.html.